BOOKS

UNCHAINED MELODY

In ***H-Pop*, Kunal Purohit** grapples with the divisive power of music

In 2019, journalist Kunal Purohit found himself in Gumla, a sleepy town in southern Jharkhand where, as he puts it, "nothing noteworthy happens." But, in 2017, something did happen. That year, a Ramnavami procession—traditionally "a demonstration of peaceful coexistence" between the town's Hindu and Muslim residents—sparked off communal tensions. Later that night, some Hindu men returning from the procession lynched and killed a local Muslim man they saw with a Hindu woman. Two years later, as Purohit talked to locals to understand what triggered the confrontation and violence, he came across an unlikely potential answer: the incendiary music blaring out of the procession's PA system, brawny bass beats laid over lyrics like "toss the mullah's cap to the ground".

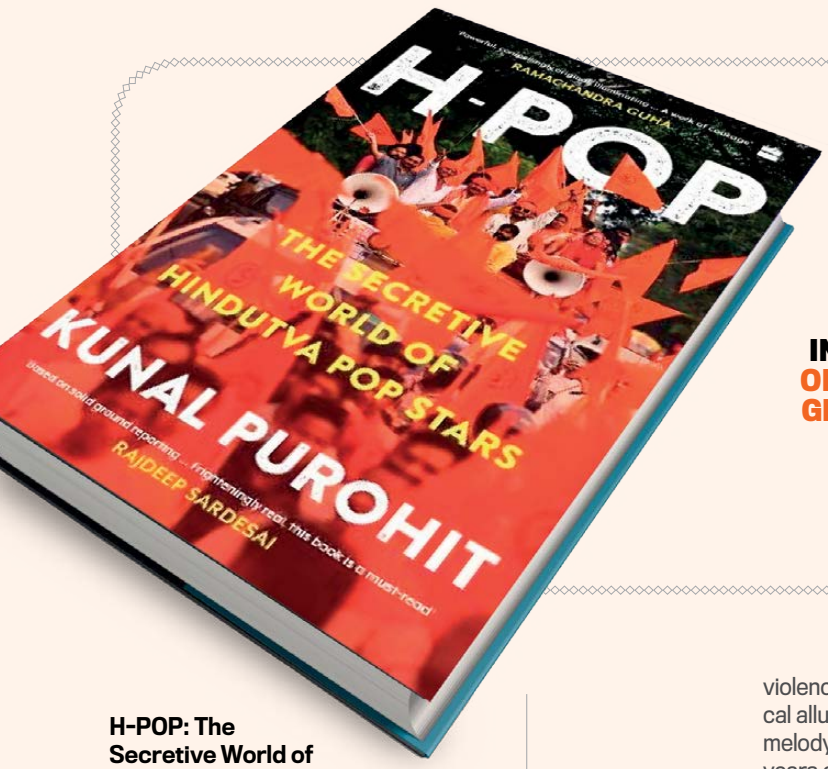
Purohit's first encounter with what he calls Hindutva Pop (or H-Pop for short) led him across northern and central India, exploring an emergent genre of Indian music steeped in right-wing nationalism and Islamophobia, its messages of hate and violence dressed up in lyrical allusion and seductive melody. Over nearly five years of on-ground reporting, he discovered an entire ecosystem of musicians, poets, social media influencers and publishing houses that is hard at work pushing the ideals and ideology of Hindu nationalism to millions of adoring fans. In *H-Pop: The Secretive World of Hindutva Pop Stars*, Purohit documents the rise of this ecosystem through in-depth profiles of three of its biggest stars.

There's Kavi Singh, a Haryanvi pop singer who went viral with her first song, a track about the 2019 Pulwama terror attack that laid the blame squarely at the feet of local Kashmiri Muslims. Kamal Agney is a firebrand poet from UP's Gosaiganj whose verses attacking Gandhi, Nehru, etc have made him popular. Sandeep Deo, a former journalist turned YouTuber, dreams of building his own Hindutva publishing and book distribution empire.

Through intimate interviews, Purohit digs deep into the motivations of these emerging stars of Hindutva pop culture, two of whom come from stolidly secular backgrounds. Through detailed analysis of the three's cultural output, he traces the contours of their revisionist vision of Indian culture and history, a terrifying cocktail of paranoia, dehumanising hate and revanchist triumphalism.

The book offers a stark warning of the dangers posed by this Hindutva cultural project. If I have any criticism, it's that Purohit's narrow focus on three individuals offers only glimpses of the scale of this project. The book also doesn't offer entirely satisfactory answers to the central questions he poses: "Can a song trigger a murder? Can a poem spark a riot? Can a book divide a people?" There are references to Radio Rwanda's role in the Rwandan genocide, and research into the use of culture by white supremacists, but Purohit struggles to establish a direct relationship between rhetoric and action, a task that is perhaps better suited to more academic efforts of cultural critique. Those looking for rigorous, definitive answers to those questions may have to look elsewhere, but H-Pop certainly provides an excellent starting point for such inquiries. ■

–Bhanuj Kappal



PUROHIT'S NARROW FOCUS ON THREE INDIVIDUALS OFFERS ONLY GLIMPSES OF THE SCALE OF THE HINDUTVA PROJECT

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